UCR Course Design Resources

Return to Index

Previous: "Accessibility"

Next: "Canvas Support"

Intermediate: Course Design and Tools

Once you are comfortable with Canvas' components as well as how to make your course accessible, you may want to 'level up' your usage. The following are suggestions for further customizing and designing your courses using both features within Canvas and some UCR-specific integrations.

Your Course Home Page

The Course Home Page provides a landing point for students and will be the first thing a student sees when they access your course. Creating an easy-to-use and engaging Home page can clarify information and encourage community support for students throughout your course.

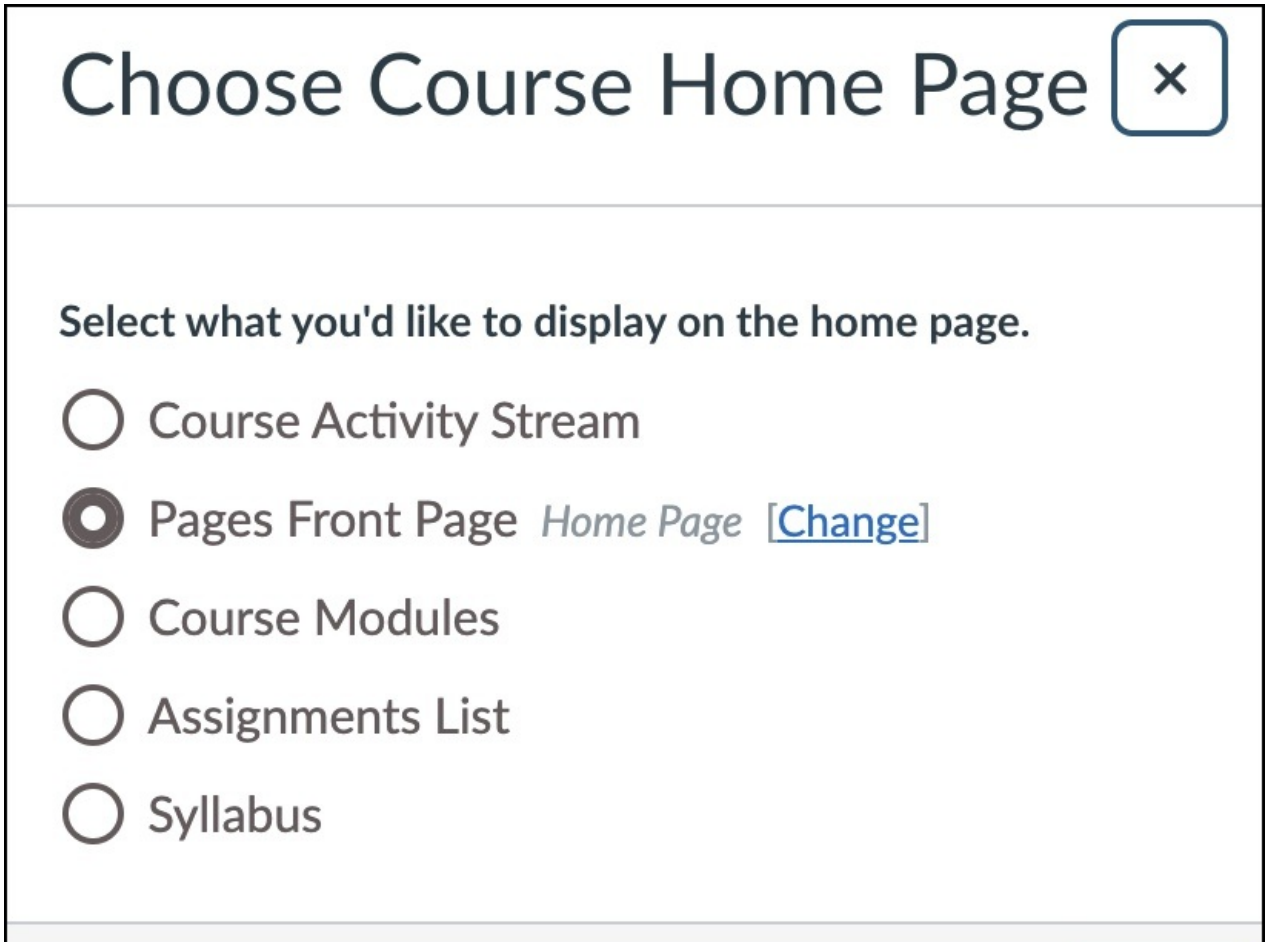
An effective and inviting Course Home Page should include the following:

- The name and section of the course
- Instructor (and TA) name(s) and contact information
- Where to find course-related information or procedures, as well as tips for success
- Meeting time and location
- Something dynamic (see section below on Cidi Labs for some design options)

For a custom Course Home Page, you will need to create a page, and then select that page as the "Front Page." Find further information about creating Canvas Pages and Home pages in the Canvas resources below.

Info: Using Canvas Pages and Home Pages

Canvas provides several options for setting a Home page from the "Choose Home Page" button in the menu on the right-hand side of the landing page in your course:



- How do I change the Course Home Page?
- Canvas Pages Overview (Video)

Choosing a Home Page

- When deciding on a Home page, take a moment to consider the content and how you want the student experience to flow.
- Recommendations and instructions for choosing a Home page in Canvas are detailed in the "Designing an Engaging Home Page for Your Course" guide.

Examples of Home Pages

Adapted with permission from UCLA's Why Does a Home Page Matter? guide.

Some Additional Canvas features that can lend dynamic elements to the Home Page of your course are the Course Activity Stream and Announcements.

The Course Activity Stream "shows you important recent activities from a single course including announcements, discussions, assignments, and conversations." Instructors have the option to set the Course Activity Stream as a Course Home Page.

You can also enable the option to "show recent announcements in the Course Home Page," which stacks a specified number of course Announcements at the top of the Course Home Page, whatever its designation.

Customizing Your Course Menu

Instructors can customize the course navigation menu by enabling, disabling, or re-ordering menu items from within the "Navigation" tab of the course "Settings."

Info: Customize the Course Navigation Menu

- How do I use the Course Navigation Menu as an instructor?
- How do I manage Course Navigation links?
- How to use the redirect tool for custom links in a Canvas Menu

Cidi Labs DesignPLUS

Info: QuickStart Wizard Tool

Cidi Labs offers the QuickStart Wizard, which allows you to quickly add designed content and templates to your course. When editing a blank Page, Announcement, or anywhere else you would normally be able to access the sidebar, there will now be a button labeled "DesignPLUS QuickStart Wizard" to the right of the Title:

Clicking into the Wizard will give you the ability to apply Templates and Content Blocks, as well as to move these items around, prior to customizing them for your purposes.

Note: The Wizard will only appear when starting with a blank slate, so to speak. Once there is saved content, the tool will no longer show.

Leverage the Cidi Labs integration with Canvas to add a more graphical element to your courses. Access the Cidi Labs tool panel by selecting the "rocketship" icon that appears in the upper-right of any Canvas item that you're editing.

Use Cidi Labs to make Canvas pages more reader-friendly through the addition of Content Blocks, Columns, Accordion Menus, Expander Menus, and Tabbed environments.

Info: Cidi Labs Resources

- Cidi Labs Knowledgebase
- Cidi Labs Training Resources
- Cidi Labs â€œUser Guideâ€ Course
- Cidi Labs Video Hub
- Cidi Labs Support
- Sign up for sequenced videos through email

Academic Technologies

Design solutions to enhance the look of your course.

Click here to learn more: Cidi Labs

Maximizes grading capabilities.

Click here to learn more: Gradescope

Better communication with your students.

Click here to learn more: Slack

Poll Everywhere

Create innovative polling experiences.

Click here to learn more: Poll Everywhere

Respondus®

For locking down online testing and remote proctoring.

Click here to learn more: Respondus

turnitin®

Anti-Plagiarism Tool.

Click here to learn more: Turnitin

Click here to learn more: Turnitin

YuJa is for media storage.

Click here to learn more: YuJa

Online conferencing and live streaming.

Click here to learn more: Zoom